

NERVOUS SYSTEM DISORDERS

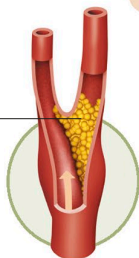
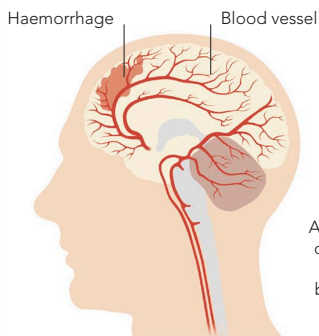
DISORDERS OF THE NERVOUS SYSTEM CAN DEVELOP FOR VARIOUS REASONS, SUCH AS PROBLEMS WITH THE BRAIN'S BLOOD SUPPLY, THE DETERIORATION OF BRAIN CELLS, ABNORMAL DEVELOPMENT IN THE WOMB, TISSUE INFECTION, CELL DAMAGE, AND THE AGEING PROCESS.

STROKE

Disruption of blood supply to nerve cells in the brain results in a temporary or permanent loss of function of the body parts they serve. In most people, symptoms of stroke develop rapidly, and may include weakness or numbness on one side of the body, visual disturbances, slurred speech, and difficulty maintaining balance. Immediate admission to hospital is essential to try to prevent brain damage. Long-term treatment to reduce the risk of further strokes usually consists of drugs. Rehabilitation, such as physiotherapy and speech therapy, are often needed. The after-effects of a stroke range from mild, temporary symptoms to lifelong disability.

Thrombus

Fat deposits in artery walls reduce flow and may encourage a blood clot, or thrombus, to form; if this blocks an artery to the brain, a stroke follows



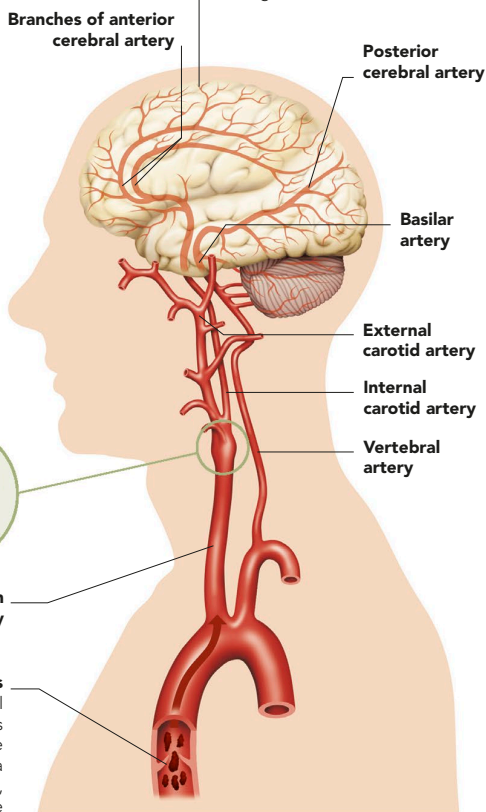
Common carotid artery

Embolus

A piece of material called an embolus may travel in the blood and block a cerebral artery, causing a stroke

Blockage of tiny vessels

Prolonged high blood pressure or diabetes may damage tiny blood vessels, which may lead to localized blockages known as lacunar strokes



BLEEDING WITHIN THE BRAIN

An intracerebral haemorrhage, bleeding within brain tissue, is a main cause of stroke in older people who have hypertension. High blood pressure may put extra strain on small arteries in the brain, which causes them to rupture.

BLOCKED BLOOD VESSELS

Blocked arteries that cause a stroke can occur for several reasons, ranging from localized blockages in tiny blood vessels deep within the brain to a blockage caused by a fragment of material that has travelled to the brain from elsewhere.